

Before the camera comes out



The questions, costs, templates
and checklists I'd want you to have
before you spend a penny on a film.

s4digital

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Why I'm giving this away

The best films come from clients who already know how a film gets made.

I make documentary-style brand films for a living. So it's fair to ask why I'd write down most of what I know and hand it out for free.

Honestly, it's a bit selfish. The best projects I've worked on have all had one thing in common. The person on the other side already understood how a film gets made. They knew the story mattered more than the kit. They knew the edit takes longer than the shoot. They'd thought about where the film would go before they asked what it would cost. Those projects are calmer, the films are better, and everybody involved enjoys them more.

The hard projects usually go wrong before anyone picks up a camera. A brief that's really a wish list. A budget nobody wanted to say out loud. A founder who's terrified of being filmed and nobody told them what the day would be like. A track that sounded great in the edit and turned out to have a licence that ran out after a year.

None of that is anyone's fault. Most people commission a film once every few years, if that, and there's no reason they should know how it works. So this is the stuff I'd tell you over a coffee if we had three hours. Use it with us, use it with someone else, or use the last section and make something on your phone this weekend. I'd genuinely be happy with any of those.

A quick note on how to read this. Every template is meant to be copied, printed or pasted into whatever you use. Fill them in badly the first time. A rough brief is far more useful than a perfect one that never gets written.



Is a brand film right for you?

A ten-point self-check, and when something cheaper is the better call.

A brand film is a big spend for most organisations. Before you go any further, it's worth being honest about whether it's the right one.

When I say brand film, I mean something specific. A short documentary about your organisation, usually four to ten minutes, built around real people telling a real story, filmed over a few days and cut with care. Its job is to make someone understand why you exist and trust you more by the end of it. It's a different thing to an advert, a product demo, a promo with stock music and drone shots, or a run of social posts.

The self-check

Tick the ones that are true. Be honest, nobody's marking it.

- ☐ Someone in the organisation genuinely cares about what you make or do, and can talk about it.
- ☐ There's a story underneath the business: a founder, a craft, a near miss, a customer or beneficiary whose life changed, a reason you exist beyond the margin.
- ☐ What you sell or ask for is built on trust. People research you before they commit, donate, apply or sign.
- ☐ Your competitors all sound roughly the same on paper.
- ☐ You know what the film is for. A launch, hiring, a stalling sales conversation, a funding bid, an anniversary, a campaign that needs something at its centre.
- ☐ You have, or can find, a realistic budget. For a properly made documentary film that's usually five figures.
- ☐ You can wait six to ten weeks from the first conversation to the finished film.
- ☐ The people who'd be in it are willing, even if they're nervous.
- ☐ You've got somewhere to put it: a website, a sales team, events, a newsletter, social channels, a board.
- ☐ You'll still be the same organisation in two or three years, so the film will still be true.

Seven or more ticks: a brand film is probably a good fit. Keep reading.

Four to six: it might be. Look hard at the ones you didn't tick, especially the purpose and the budget. Those two decide most projects.

Three or fewer: I'd hold off and look at the options below first.

When something cheaper is the better call

I'd rather lose a project than sell someone the wrong thing. Here's when I'd tell you to spend less.

You need volume, not depth. If the real need is twenty posts a month, a single film won't fix that. You want a content partnership: regular shoot days, short-form video, photography, someone planning and posting it. At s4digital that's **Momentum, from £1,800 + VAT a month**, or **Studio, from £2,500 + VAT a month** if you want us to take on more of the marketing function.

You need good pictures and a few clips of you. If you're a founder, consultant or coach building a name and you already know what to do with the content, a single shoot day is usually enough. Ours is **Spotlight, a one-off shoot at £795 + VAT**.

You need it next week. A documentary film can't be rushed, because most of the quality comes from the research and the edit. If the deadline is fixed and close, make something simpler and plan the film properly for later.

You need to show how a product works. A clear demo or explainer will do that job better and cheaper.

You're about to change. New name, new leadership, new offer coming in six months? Wait. A film about the old version of you ages badly.

The budget's small and fixed. Under a few thousand pounds, a well-planned shoot with a good freelancer, or the phone guide at the end of this playbook, will get you further than a stretched "film" that has to cut every corner.

Every option on that list is fine. The mistake is buying the expensive thing for a job the cheap thing does better, or the cheap thing for a job only the expensive one can do.



Finding the story

Thirty questions to run with your team before anyone picks up a camera.

This is the bit most people skip, and it's the bit that decides whether the film is any good.

When a business first thinks about a film, the story it reaches for is nearly always the official one. What we do, who we do it for, our values, our product range. That's the brochure. Nobody shares a brochure.

The story that works is usually hiding somewhere less obvious. The person who started it and why. The thing that nearly went wrong. The part of the process that almost nobody outside gets to see. The customer whose life quietly changed. The volunteer who's turned up every Tuesday for eleven years. Those are the films people watch to the end and send to someone else.

How to dig for it

Talk to more people than you think you need. The founder knows the official story best, which can make them the worst person to find the real one. Talk to the longest-serving staff member, the newest one, someone on the shop floor, a customer, a supplier.

Ask for moments, not opinions. "What makes us different?" gets you a slogan. "Tell me about the day you nearly closed" gets you a story.

Listen for energy. When someone leans in, speeds up, laughs or goes quiet, that's where the story is. Write down what they were talking about.

Look for tension. Every good story has something at stake. A risk, a problem, a before and after, a choice that could have gone the other way. If everything's always been easy, there isn't much of a film.

Write down the exact words. People say things in a way you'd never write. Keep their phrasing, because it's often the line that ends up carrying the film.

Go and watch the work. Spend an hour where the work happens. You'll spot things that are so normal to the team they'd never mention them.

Pick one story. You'll find five. A film that tries to tell all of them tells none of them. Pick the one with the most at stake and the best person to tell it.

The story question bank

Run these as conversations, not a survey. Twenty minutes with each person, in a quiet room, notebook out. Record it on your phone if they're happy with that, so you can listen back for the exact words.

For the founder or leader

1. What were you doing the year before you started this?

2. What was the moment you decided to actually do it?
3. Who told you it wouldn't work, and what did they say?
4. What was the closest you came to giving up? What happened that week?
5. What did you get badly wrong early on?
6. What's something you do here that you'd keep doing even if it cost you money?
7. What do you wish customers understood about the work that they never see?
8. Who's the person in the business you'd least want to lose, and why?
9. If the business disappeared tomorrow, who would actually notice?
10. What still annoys you about your industry?

For staff, volunteers or the team

11. Talk me through what your day actually looks like, start to finish.
12. What's the hardest part of your job that nobody outside would guess?
13. How long did it take you to get properly good at it? What changed?
14. What's a job or a day here you'll always remember?
15. What did you think this place would be like before you joined, and what's it actually like?
16. Is there a customer or person you've helped that you still think about?
17. What's the thing you're proudest of here that nobody's ever thanked you for?
18. What's a phrase or a habit that only people here would understand?

For customers, clients, beneficiaries or visitors

19. What was going on for you before you found them?
20. What nearly stopped you choosing them?
21. What did you expect, and what actually happened?
22. Was there a specific moment you thought "right, this is different"?
23. What's changed since, day to day?
24. Who have you told about them, and what did you say?
25. If they disappeared, what would you do instead?

For partners, suppliers, trustees or long-standing supporters

26. How did you first come across them?
27. What do they do that others in the sector don't?

28. What's a time they handled something difficult well?
29. Why have you stuck with them?
30. What do you think they're still underrating about themselves?

Turning answers into a story

After the conversations, sit down with your notes and fill this in. It's the same shape we use to pitch a story back to a client.

Question	Your answer
Whose story is it? (one person, or one small group)	
What did they want?	
What was in the way, or at stake?	
What happened? (the moment it turned)	
What's different now?	
What do we want a viewer to feel or understand at the end?	
Best line someone said, word for word	
What would we need to film to show this, rather than just say it?	

If you can fill in the first five rows in plain sentences, you've got a film. If you're struggling with row three, keep digging. A story with nothing at stake reads as a nice video about nice people, and that's hard to watch twice.

Don't be surprised if the best story isn't the founder's. Often the founder is the right person to set it up and someone else is the right person to carry it.



The interview question bank

The questions that get people talking on camera, by who's in the chair.

The story conversations above are for you. These ones are for camera. The difference is that on the day you want answers that work as standalone clips, told as stories, with feeling, in the person's own words.

Before you ask anything

- **Explain that they should include the question in their answer.** The interviewer's voice gets cut out, so "Since 2011" is useless. "I've been doing this since 2011" works. Tell them once at the start and gently remind them if they forget.
- **Start easy.** Their name, their role, what they had for breakfast. The first ten minutes are a warm-up. Nobody's best answers come early.
- **Look at the interviewer, not the lens.** Sit the interviewer just beside the camera at the subject's eye height.
- **Don't nod with sound.** No "mm-hm", no "yeah". Nod silently and smile. Every noise you make is one they can't use.
- **Let silence sit.** After they finish, wait three or four seconds before you speak. People nearly always add the best bit into that gap.
- **Ask one question at a time.** Two-part questions get half-answers.
- **Don't send the questions in advance word for word.** Send the themes. Rehearsed answers sound rehearsed.

Follow-ups that do the heavy lifting

Most of the good material comes from the follow-up. Keep these in your back pocket:

- "Tell me more about that."
- "What do you mean by that?"
- "Can you take me back to that day? Where were you?"
- "How did that feel at the time?"
- "What happened next?"
- "Can you give me an example?"
- "What would you say to someone who's where you were then?"
- "That was great. Could you say it again in one or two sentences?"
- "If you had to explain that to your gran, how would you put it?"
- "Is there anything I haven't asked that I should have?"

That last one goes at the end of every interview. It's surprising how often it's where the film comes from.

Founder or leader

1. Tell me who you are and what this place is, as if I'd just walked in off the street.
2. Take me back to the very beginning. Where were you, and what made you start?
3. What did people around you say when you told them?
4. What were the first months like?
5. Tell me about a time it nearly didn't work.
6. What got you through that?
7. What's a decision you made that cost you in the short term but you'd make again?
8. Describe the work itself. What does doing it properly look like?
9. What's a part of the job nobody outside gets to see?
10. Who are the people you do this for? Describe one of them.
11. What's a moment from the last year that reminded you why you do it?
12. What does this place look like in ten years if it goes the way you want?
13. What would you want someone to feel after watching this?

Staff, team members or volunteers

1. What's your name and what do you do here, in your own words?
2. How did you end up here?
3. Walk me through a normal day.
4. What's the bit of your job you'd do even if nobody paid you?
5. What's the hardest bit?
6. Tell me about someone you've helped, or a job you've done, that stuck with you.
7. What did you have to learn the hard way?
8. What's it like working with the people here?
9. What do you think customers don't realise about what goes into it?
10. What would you tell someone thinking about joining?

Customers, clients, beneficiaries or visitors

1. Tell me a bit about yourself and how you first came across them.
2. What was going on for you at the time?
3. What were you worried about before you got in touch?
4. What happened when you first met them?
5. Was there a moment you realised it was going to be different?
6. What's changed for you since?
7. Can you describe an ordinary day now compared to before?
8. What would you say to someone who's where you were?
9. If you had to describe them in a sentence to a friend, what would you say?

Never put words in a customer's mouth. If they don't say the thing you hoped, that's useful information about your business. A film where a customer reads your tagline back to you is obvious to every viewer.

Charities and heritage organisations

1. What does this place, or this cause, mean to the people it serves?
2. Tell me about the first person or object that made you understand why it matters.
3. What would be lost if this didn't exist?
4. What's a story from the archive, the collection or the community that people should know?
5. Who were the people who built this before you?
6. What's the hardest thing about keeping it going?
7. What does support actually make possible? Give me one real example.
8. What do you want the next generation to understand about it?

For anyone sharing a difficult personal experience, agree in advance what they're comfortable talking about, tell them they can stop at any point, and make sure they know they can ask for something to be left out afterwards. Then honour it.



What things cost

Where the money goes, line by line, with a planner to fill in.

I'd rather put numbers in front of you than make you book a call to find them out.

Two companies can quote £3,000 and £30,000 for what sounds like the same brief, and both can be fair. The difference is nearly always in what's included, and most of it is work you can't see on the finished film. Here's where the money goes.

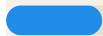
First, the bands

These are rough UK market ranges from what I see across the industry. **They're typical market ranges, not quotes**, and you'll find good people charging above and below every one of them.



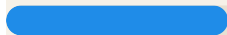
Under £2,000

A freelancer, a day or less on site, an interview and some B-roll, a short edit, library music. Fine for social content and simple talking heads.



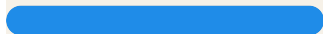
£2,000 to £8,000

A small production company or experienced freelance team. One or two shoot days, a scripted or interview-led piece, a proper edit, often a couple of cut-downs. Most corporate video sits here.



£8,000 to £30,000

Documentary brand films and higher-end brand content. Real research, multi-day shoots, a crew, a specialist grade and mix, a full set of cuts.



£30,000 and up

Agency-led campaigns, scripted work with cast and art direction, built sets, broadcast advertising.

Where s4digital sits: our films start from **£15,000 + VAT**, and most land between **£15,000 and £25,000 + VAT**. Each one's quoted as one fixed figure, agreed in full before anything is booked. Research, two to three shoot days on a cinema camera with proper sound, the edit, the grade, the mix and a full indefinite licence for every platform are all inside it. You get the main film (usually four to ten minutes), a sixty to ninety second cut, six to ten vertical pieces and stills from the same days.

Remember VAT. Most UK production companies quote excluding VAT, so a £15,000 + VAT film is £18,000 once 20% VAT is added. If your organisation can't reclaim VAT, which is common for some charities, budget for the gross figure.

Line by line

Again, **these are typical UK market ranges, not quotes**. Some companies price line by line, others (us included) quote a fixed total that covers all of this. Either way, these are the pieces inside it.

Line	What it is	Typical UK market range	What moves the price
Pre-production and research	Story conversations, recce visits, pre-interviews, planning, scheduling, call sheets	£500 to £3,000+, often bundled into the total	How many people to talk to, how complex the story is
Director / producer	The person responsible for the story and the day	£400 to £1,000 per day	Experience, prep days on top of shoot days
Camera operator / DoP	Shoots the film, often with their own camera package	£400 to £1,200 per day including basic kit	Camera level, lighting needs, experience
Sound recordist	Records clean audio on set	£350 to £650 per day with kit	Number of people mic'd, location noise
Second camera	A second angle on interviews or events	£350 to £800 per day	Whether it's a full operator or a locked-off camera
Kit hire	Cinema camera, lenses, lights, grip, if not included	£150 to £1,000+ per day	Camera tier, lighting package
Drone	Aerial footage by a licensed operator	£400 to £1,200 per day	Location permissions, flight restrictions
Stills photographer	Photos from the same days	£400 to £1,200 per day	Edited image count, usage
Locations	Studio hire, permits, location fees	£0 on your own premises; studio £400 to £2,000+ per day	Hired space, public filming permissions
Travel and expenses	Mileage, trains, parking, congestion charge, hotels, food	Varies	Distance, number of days, crew size

Line	What it is	Typical UK market range	What moves the price
Insurance	Public liability, equipment cover	Usually inside the company's rates	Ask to see it, don't pay for it separately
Edit	Editor's time finding and building the film	£300 to £600 per day; a documentary film can take one to three weeks	Hours of footage, number of revision rounds
Colour grade	Specialist colour work	£400 to £1,000 per day; half a day to two days per film	Length of film, consistency issues in footage
Sound mix	Cleaning dialogue, balancing music and sound	£300 to £800 per day; half a day to two days	Problem audio, number of versions
Music licensing	The right to use a track	£0 to £500 per track for library music; thousands for a commercial track	Platforms, territories, term, paid ads
Motion graphics	Titles, lower thirds, simple animated elements	£200 to £1,500+	Complexity, number of graphics
Captions and subtitles	Burned-in or caption files for each cut	£0 to £300 per film	Number of cuts, languages, human proofreading
Cut-downs	Shorter and vertical versions from the same footage	£150 to £600 per cut	Reframing, new structure, captions included or not
Contingency	A buffer for the unexpected	5% to 10% of the total	How fixed the plan is

Why cheap is cheap

A cheap video is usually one person, one day and one camera, with an edit turned round in a couple of days and a stock track underneath. For plenty of jobs that's the right call. Event recaps, a quick product demo, a talking head for LinkedIn.

What drops out at that price is the work you can't see. The research. The second shoot day, when people finally stop noticing the camera. Time in the edit to find the story instead of assembling shots. A proper grade and mix. You end up with something that says what every other company in your sector says about itself.

If a quote allows two days of editing for a six minute documentary, it's a quote for a different kind of film. That's the single quickest check I know.

Should you tell them your budget?

Yes. I know it feels like handing over your negotiating position, but a good production company will design the film around what you can actually spend. If your budget's £6,000 I'd much rather hear that on the first call and point you somewhere useful than send a £20,000 proposal and never hear back.

Budget planner

Copy this and fill it in. Get quotes against the same lines from each company you talk to so you're comparing like with like.

Line	Included? (Y/N)	Days / quantity	Rate	Total	Notes
Pre-production and research					
Director / producer					
Camera operator / DoP					
Sound recordist					
Second camera					
Kit hire					
Drone					
Stills photographer					
Locations and permits					
Travel and expenses					
Edit					
Colour grade					
Sound mix					
Music licence					
Motion graphics					
Captions and subtitles					
Cut-downs (how many?)					

Line	Included? (Y/N)	Days / quantity	Rate	Total	Notes
Contingency (5% to 10%)					
Subtotal (ex VAT)					
VAT at 20%					
Total					
Internal costs (staff time, venue, refreshments)					
<i>Don't forget the internal cost. Your people's time for research conversations, the shoot days and review rounds is real. It's usually two or three days spread across a few people, plus whoever's managing the project.</i>					



Writing a brief

A template any production company can actually work from.

A good brief doesn't need to be long. One or two pages is plenty. What it needs is honesty, particularly about the budget, the purpose and what you're nervous about.

Fill this in, send it to whoever you're talking to, and ask them to tell you what's missing.

The brief template

1. About us Who are we, in three sentences a stranger would understand? How long have we been going, how big are we, where are we?

2. Why now What's happening that makes this the right moment? A launch, an anniversary, a funding round, a hiring push, a rebrand, a campaign, a new site.

3. What the film is for Pick one main job. Win trust with buyers who research before they commit? Help the sales team? Recruit? Support a funding bid? Tell the story of a place before it changes? If there are two jobs, put them in order.

4. Who needs to see it Describe one real person in the audience. Their job, what they already know about us, what they're sceptical about, where they'll watch it (phone on the train, laptop at a desk, big screen at an event).

5. What we want them to think, feel or do afterwards One sentence for each, if you can. "Think: these people really know what they're doing. Feel: I'd trust them with this. Do: book a call."

6. The story we think it might be What you've found from the story questions in section 3. Who's the main person? What's at stake? It's fine to have two or three options. A good production company will help you choose.

7. Who could be in it Names and roles of possible contributors. Note who's keen, who's nervous and who'd need persuading.

8. Where it could be filmed Your premises, sites, customers' places, outdoors. Any access issues, restricted areas, noise, opening hours, safety inductions?

9. Things we must include Be strict. Every "must" makes the film longer and weaker. Logo at the end and a web address is normal. A list of twelve services is a brochure.

10. Things we must avoid Topics, people, places, competitors, claims we can't make, anything legally sensitive, anything a regulator would care about.

11. Films we like (and why) Two or three links, with a line on what you like about each. Tone, pace, look, length. Also one you don't like, and why. That's often more useful.

12. Deliverables we think we need Main film length, short cut for the website, vertical cuts for social, stills, subtitled versions, a version for events with no sound.

13. Where it'll go Website, YouTube, LinkedIn, Instagram, email, events, sales presentations, recruitment, internal. Any paid advertising? (This matters for music licences.)

14. Budget A number or a range, including or excluding VAT. If you really can't share it, say what you'd be uncomfortable going above.

15. Timings When do you need it by, and why? Are there dates people aren't available? Busy seasons to avoid?

16. Who signs it off Name the person who has final say, and anyone else who'll review. Fewer reviewers means a better film.

17. What worries us Being honest here is the most useful thing you can do. Nervous founder? Previous video that didn't work? A board that's sceptical? Write it down.

Section 17 is the one people leave blank, and it's the one I read first. Every worry you mention early is one we can design around. Every one you don't tends to turn up at rough cut.



Hiring a production company

Twenty questions to ask, the red flags, and what a good quote includes.

You'll talk to a few companies, they'll all have a nice showreel, and they'll all say they tell stories. Here's how to tell them apart.

Questions to ask

1. Can I see two or three full films you've made that are similar to what we want, not just a showreel?
2. Who will actually be on set, and who'll be in the edit? Is the person I'm talking to involved?
3. Is research and story development included, or am I writing the brief and script myself?
4. How do you find the story? What does that process look like week by week?
5. How many shoot days do you think this needs, and why that number?
6. Who's on the crew each day?
7. What camera and sound setup will you use? Is sound recorded by a dedicated person?
8. How long is the edit, roughly, in days?
9. When do we see it, and how many rounds of changes are included at each stage?
10. Is the colour grade and sound mix done by specialists, or by the editor?
11. What music will you use, what does the licence cover, and does it ever run out?
12. Which cuts come back, in which formats and aspect ratios? Are captions included?
13. Who owns the footage and the finished film? What licence do we get, and is it in writing?
14. Do we get the raw footage? If not, can we buy it, and for how much?
15. How do you handle consent and release forms for people on camera?
16. Are you insured? Can we see public liability and equipment cover?
17. What's not included in this quote that we might end up paying for?
18. What are your payment terms, and what happens if we need to move a shoot date?
19. What would make you say this isn't a project for you?
20. Can I speak to a past client?

Question 19 is a good one. A company that can tell you when it wouldn't take a job has thought about what it's good at.

Red flags

- ☐ They talk about cameras and drones before they ask what the film is for.
- ☐ They can't show you a full film, only a showreel of nice shots.
- ☐ The quote is one line with a total and nothing else.
- ☐ There's no mention of music licensing, or "we'll use royalty-free music" with no detail.
- ☐ They're vague about who owns what, or the licence is limited and they don't mention it.
- ☐ They say yes to everything on your must-include list without pushing back.
- ☐ Edit time looks tiny compared to the length of film you want.
- ☐ No mention of release forms or consent.
- ☐ No insurance, or they go quiet when you ask.
- ☐ A day rate that keeps growing with no cap or estimate.
- ☐ Pressure to sign quickly for a "discount that ends Friday".
- ☐ They promise views, virality or results they can't control.

One red flag isn't a dealbreaker on its own. Three or four together usually tells you how the project will go.

What a good quote includes

- ☐ A short summary of the story or approach, in plain English, showing they listened
- ☐ What the film is for and who it's aimed at
- ☐ The number of research, shoot and edit days, or a fixed total that clearly includes them
- ☐ Crew on each day
- ☐ Every deliverable: lengths, formats, aspect ratios, captions, stills
- ☐ Revision rounds, and at which stage (rough cut, fine cut)
- ☐ Grade and mix, and who does them
- ☐ Music: where it's from and what the licence covers
- ☐ Ownership and licence terms for you: where you can use it, for how long
- ☐ What's not included
- ☐ Timeline with key dates
- ☐ Payment terms and cancellation or rescheduling terms
- ☐ Prices clearly marked as including or excluding VAT



Getting your people ready to be filmed

A prep sheet for anyone who's never been filmed before.

This is a one-page prep sheet. Print it and give it to everyone who's going to be on camera, a week before the shoot.

Your filming day: a prep sheet

What's going to happen A small crew will arrive, set up for about an hour, and then film a relaxed conversation with you. It's a chat, not a speech. Nothing is live. Nothing goes out without you having a chance to see it. If you stumble, you just start again. Everybody does.

How long it takes Allow around an hour to an hour and a half for your interview, including setup of your microphone and a bit of warming up. We may also film you working for a while afterwards. Just do what you'd normally do.

What to wear - Wear what you'd normally wear for work, on a good day. You should feel like yourself. - Solid colours and soft patterns are best. Avoid very fine stripes, small checks and tight patterns, because they can shimmer on camera. - Avoid pure bright white and solid black if you can. Mid-tones look best. - Avoid big logos (yours is fine) and anything with slogans. - A top with a collar, buttons or a jacket makes it easier to hide a microphone. Avoid noisy fabrics like crisp synthetic shirts. - Avoid jangly jewellery or anything that clicks or rustles. - Bring a second top in case of a spill or a clash with the background. - Glasses are fine. If you wear them every day, wear them.

Hair and face - Do what you'd normally do. A recent haircut is fine, a dramatic new one isn't necessary. - A bit of powder takes the shine off, for anyone. We may have some. - Bring lip balm and water.

The microphone We'll clip a small microphone to your clothing, usually around chest height, and the wire or transmitter goes under your top or on your belt. Someone will ask before helping you with it. Once it's on, it hears everything, including in the toilet and chats in the corridor. We'll take it off at breaks.

Nerves - Being nervous is normal and it doesn't show nearly as much as you think. - You're not expected to remember anything. There's no script. - Look at the person asking questions, not the camera. - If you lose your thread, stop, breathe, and start the sentence again. We'll edit it. - Say your answers in full sentences that include the question. "I started the business in 2015", not just "2015". - Talk to the interviewer like you'd talk to a friend who's interested in what you do. - The first ten minutes are a warm-up. Don't judge yourself on them. - If something's off limits, tell us before we start. You can also ask us afterwards to leave anything out.

The night before - Get a decent night's sleep. - Don't rehearse answers word for word. Just think about two or three stories you'd like to tell. - Lay your clothes out.

On the day - Eat beforehand, but nothing too heavy. - Drink water. Avoid lots of caffeine right before your interview. - Turn your phone off, not just on silent. Silent phones still buzz near the microphone. - Take off smart watches that vibrate or beep. - Let colleagues know you're being filmed so nobody walks in mid-sentence.

Release form You'll be asked to sign a form giving permission to use what we film. Read it, ask anything you're unsure about, and keep a copy.

What happens next The edit takes a few weeks. A small group will see an early version first. You'll see your part before anything goes public.

For whoever's organising the shoot: protect people's diaries properly. Someone squeezing an interview between two meetings is distracted and rushed, and it shows in every answer.



Shot list template for B-roll

The pictures that carry the story while people talk.

B-roll is everything that isn't the interview. It's what the audience looks at while people talk, and it's what makes a film feel like it's showing you something rather than telling you. In documentary work most of it is real work happening for real, and you just need to make sure you're there when it does.

How to think about B-roll

- **Shoot sequences.** For any action, get a wide (where are we), a mid (what's happening) and a close-up (the detail: hands, tools, faces). Three angles of one action can be cut together. One angle can't.
- **Hold each shot for at least ten seconds.** Count it. The edit needs room either side.
- **Get the details.** Hands at work, tools, materials, labels, the kettle, the sign on the door, worn bits of the workshop. Detail shots are what make a place feel real.
- **Film people working, then working with each other.** Conversations, handovers, laughing in the kitchen.
- **Get the space at different times.** Arrival before anyone's in, busy middle of the day, lights going off.
- **Capture the ambient sound.** Thirty seconds of room tone in every location, with everyone quiet. The edit will need it.
- **Shoot what people mention.** If the founder talks about the first van, find the first van.

The shot list template

#	Scene / section of story	Shot description	Shot size (wide / mid / close / detail)	Location	Who's in it	Time of day	Kit or access needed	Priority (must / nice)	Done
1	Opening: the space	Exterior of the building, sign visible	Wide	Front entrance	Nobody	Early morning	Tripod	Must	
2	Opening: the space	Unlocking the door, lights coming on	Mid then close	Front door, inside	Founder	Early morning		Must	
3	The work	Hands at work on the core task	Close / detail	Workshop	Team member	Mid-morning		Must	
4	The work	Same task from across the room	Wide	Workshop	Team member	Mid-morning		Must	
5	The people	Team talking over a job	Mid	Office / site	Team	Afternoon	Second mic	Nice	
6									
7									
8									
9									
10									

The first five rows are examples to show the level of detail. Replace them with yours.

A starter checklist of B-roll most organisations need

- ☐ Exterior of the building or site, ideally at two times of day
- ☐ Signage, entrance, arrival
- ☐ The core work in a wide, a mid and a close-up
- ☐ Hands, tools, materials and details
- ☐ The team working together
- ☐ A customer, client, visitor or beneficiary interaction (with consent)
- ☐ The product or result finished
- ☐ Each interviewee doing their actual job
- ☐ Each interviewee in a quiet moment (walking in, making a tea, looking out the window)
- ☐ Something that shows scale or context (the street, the town, the van on the road)
- ☐ Archive material: old photos, documents, early products, newspaper cuttings
- ☐ Room tone in every location



Licensing and copyright checklist

How to stay out of claim letters. General guidance, not legal advice.

Please read this first. This section is general guidance from working practice in UK production. It isn't legal advice. Copyright, data protection and image rights can get complicated quickly, and the rules differ outside the UK. If you're unsure about anything, or there's a lot at stake, speak to a solicitor who works in media or intellectual property.

Why businesses get copyright demand letters

It's very common for UK businesses to receive a letter asking for payment because an image, a piece of music or a video on their website or social channels was used without a licence. Some photo libraries and rights-management firms run software that scans the internet for their images and sends a demand when they find one being used without permission. Music is identified automatically by platforms like YouTube, which can claim, block or mute a video.

It usually happens for one of these reasons:

- Someone found an image on Google and assumed that because it was online it was free to use.
- A designer or agency used an image years ago and nobody kept the licence.
- "Royalty free" was read as "free". Royalty-free means you pay once instead of per use. You still need a licence.
- A licence covered one use (a print brochure, say) and the image was later reused on the website.
- A music subscription lapsed and nobody checked what that meant for videos already published.
- A track was licensed for organic social posts and then used in a paid advert.
- A trial version of a font was used in a final piece.

These letters are often for hundreds or thousands of pounds, and they arrive long after anyone remembers where the image came from. The cure is boring: keep records.

Music

- ☐ Every track in every cut has a licence, and you have a copy of it.
- ☐ The licence covers every platform you'll use: website, YouTube, social, events, broadcast if relevant.

- ☐ It covers paid advertising if you'll run the film as an ad. Many standard licences don't.
- ☐ You know the term. Does the licence last forever, or for a year, or for as long as a subscription runs?
- ☐ You know what happens if the subscription ends. Some libraries clear content published during the subscription forever, some don't. Check the specific terms.
- ☐ If the production company licensed the music, the licence is in your name or explicitly passes to you.
- ☐ You know how to clear a YouTube Content ID claim if one appears (usually by adding your licence code or contacting the library).
- ☐ No commercial tracks (songs you'd recognise from the radio) unless they've been properly cleared with both the publisher and the record label. That's two separate licences and it's rarely cheap.

Stock footage and photos

- ☐ Every stock clip and image has a licence, saved somewhere you'll find it in three years.
- ☐ The licence type covers commercial use.
- ☐ Editorial-only images aren't being used to promote anything. Editorial licences generally don't allow it.
- ☐ Images with identifiable people or property have the right releases from the library.
- ☐ No images taken from Google, Pinterest, social media or other websites without permission.
- ☐ Old images on your website from previous agencies have been checked, or removed if nobody can find the licence.

Fonts

- ☐ Every font used in titles and graphics is licensed for the use, or is genuinely free for commercial use (for example under the SIL Open Font Licence).
- ☐ You know the font licence type. Desktop, web, app and broadcast licences can be separate. Most fonts used in a video are covered by a desktop licence, but check the specific licence.
- ☐ No trial or demo fonts in final work.

Your own photos, archive and brand assets

- ☐ You know who took your photos and whether you own them or just have a licence.
- ☐ Archive images from local papers, archives or family collections have permission from whoever holds the rights.
- ☐ Logos of partners, clients or funders are used with their agreement.

People: consent and release forms

Under UK GDPR, footage of an identifiable person is personal data. You need a lawful basis to use it, and for marketing use the normal, sensible approach is a signed release.

- ☐ Every interviewee has signed a release form before or on the day.
- ☐ Anyone identifiable in B-roll who's prominent in shot has signed a release.
- ☐ The release covers the uses you plan: which media, which platforms, how long, and whether it includes paid advertising.
- ☐ For anyone under 18, a parent or guardian has signed. Think carefully before filming children at all, and follow any safeguarding policy your organisation has.
- ☐ For vulnerable people, you've thought about whether they can genuinely give informed consent, and how they'd withdraw it.
- ☐ People in the background of busy spaces have been told filming is happening (a sign at the entrance is common practice) and given the chance to avoid the camera.
- ☐ You've agreed what you'll do if someone asks to be removed later, such as leaving their contribution out of new edits.
- ☐ Release forms are stored securely with your other records.

What a basic release form usually covers: name and contact details, what's being filmed and by whom, the organisation using it, how and where it'll be used, how long for, that it may be edited, whether any payment is involved, consent for anyone under 18 from a parent or guardian, signature and date. Get a solicitor to check your template once, then use it for everything.

Places and property

- ☐ You have written permission from the owner or manager of every location you film.
- ☐ Filming in public spaces has been checked with the local council if you're setting up kit, blocking pavements or using a drone. Rules vary by area.

- ☐ Any drone operator holds the right UK Civil Aviation Authority registrations and is insured.
- ☐ Artwork, murals and other people's branded products aren't featured prominently without thought.
- ☐ Confidential screens, whiteboards and paperwork are cleared or covered before you roll.

Who owns the film

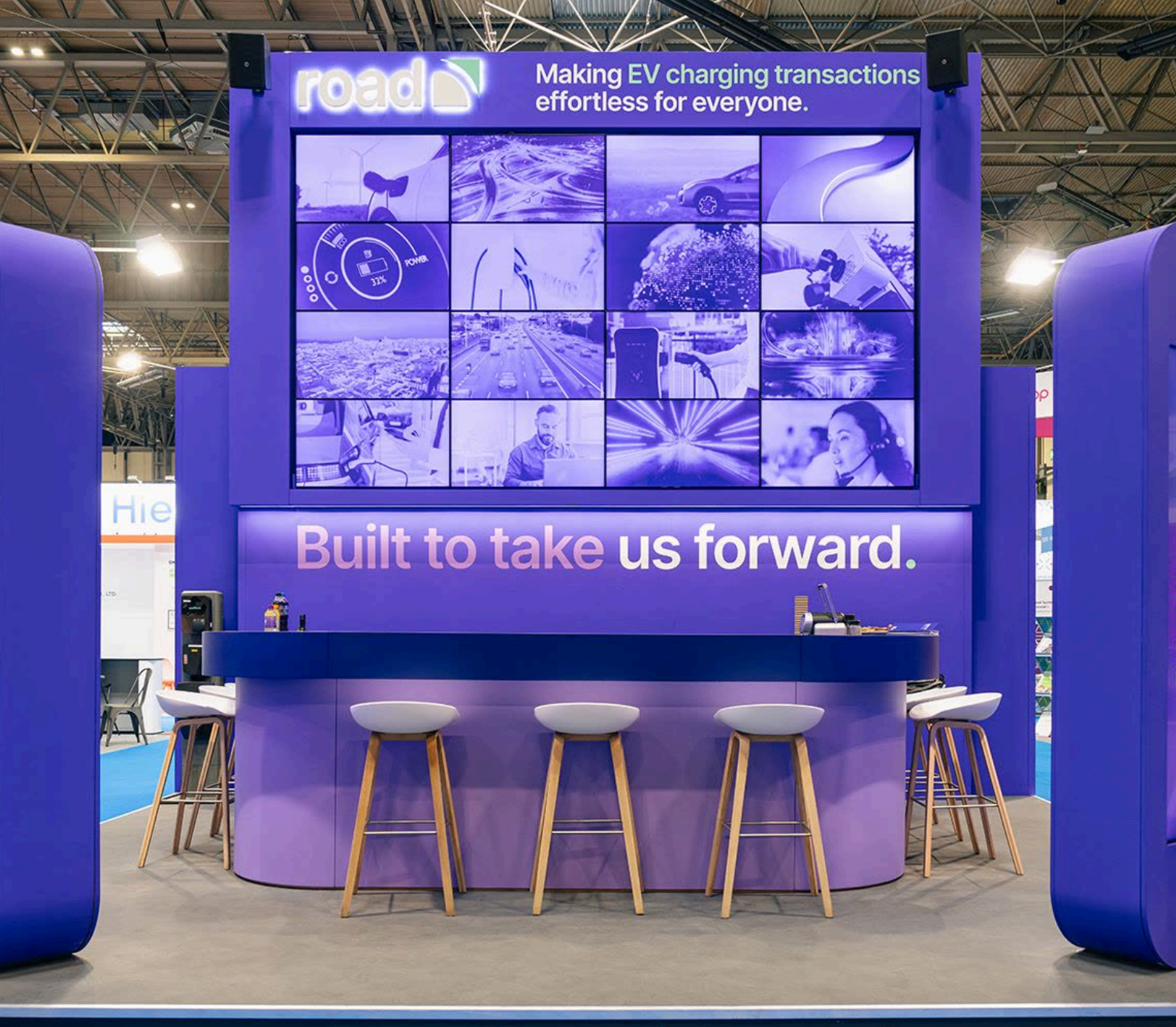
This one surprises people. In the UK, as a general rule, paying someone to make something doesn't automatically mean you own the copyright in it. Unless the contract says otherwise, the copyright in a commissioned film usually stays with whoever made it, and what you get is a licence to use it.

- ☐ The contract says clearly whether you own the copyright or have a licence.
- ☐ If it's a licence, it covers everywhere you'll use it, with no expiry date, or a date you're happy with.
- ☐ It says whether you can edit it yourself later, make new cuts or hand it to another agency.
- ☐ It says whether the production company can use it in their portfolio.
- ☐ It says what happens to the raw footage.

s4digital films come with a full licence, indefinite, every platform. Whoever you work with, get the equivalent in writing before you sign, not after the film's finished.

Accessibility

- ☐ Every cut has captions, checked by a human. Automatic captions get names, places and jargon wrong.
- ☐ Captions are available as a file (usually .srt) as well as burned in where needed.
- ☐ On-screen text is big enough and on screen long enough to read.
- ☐ If the film carries important information only in visuals, think about whether an audio-described version is needed, particularly for public sector or charity audiences.



Distribution: a 30-day release plan

Thirty days to launch a film, and a year of reuse.

This is where most films are wasted. A film goes on the homepage, gets one LinkedIn post, and is never mentioned again. You spent months making it. Plan at least as long getting it in front of people.

Before day one: what to have ready

- ☐ All cuts exported in the right formats: main film (16:9), short cut (16:9 and 1:1 or 4:5), vertical cuts (9:16)
- ☐ Caption files for every cut, proofread
- ☐ A thumbnail for YouTube and the website, made from a real frame
- ☐ A title and a description for YouTube with your key search terms in plain English
- ☐ Stills from the shoot, edited and sized
- ☐ Two or three pull quotes from the interviews, word for word
- ☐ A short write-up: what the film is about, who's in it, why you made it
- ☐ A landing page or a section on the site where the film lives
- ☐ Everyone in the film has seen it and is happy
- ☐ A list of people to send it to personally
- ☐ Music and release forms filed

The plan

When	Where	What goes out	Who owns it
Day -7	Internal	Show the whole team first. A screening over lunch, or the link with a personal note. They should never see it on LinkedIn before they've seen it from you.	Founder / leader
Day -3	Contributors	Send each person in the film their own clip and the full film, with a thank you, and ask them to share it on the day.	Project lead
Day -1	Sales and frontline teams	Brief them. Which cut to use when, a one-line description to put in emails, and a suggested way to introduce it on calls.	Sales lead
Day 1	Website	Short cut as the homepage hero (muted autoplay, captions on, link to the full film). Full film on its own page and on the About page.	Web / marketing
Day 1	YouTube	Full film published with a proper title, description, chapters if it's long, captions uploaded, thumbnail.	Marketing
Day 1	LinkedIn	Founder posts the film natively (uploaded directly, not as a YouTube link) with a personal story about why you made it. Company page shares it.	Founder
Day 2	Email	Newsletter to your list: a short note, a still, one line from the film, a link to the page.	Marketing
Day 3	Instagram / Facebook	First vertical cut as a Reel. Caption with a real line from the film.	Marketing
Day 4	Contributors	Contributors share their own clip or the full film. Tag and thank them.	Project lead
Day 5	LinkedIn	A second post from a different person in the film: staff member, customer or partner.	Contributor
Day 7	Personal sends	Personal emails from the leadership to fifteen to thirty people who matter: key clients, funders, partners, prospects you're mid-conversation with. One line and a link.	Leadership
Day 8	Social	Second vertical cut.	Marketing
Day 10	Blog / news	A behind-the-scenes or "why we made this" article with stills, the film embedded.	Marketing

When	Where	What goes out	Who owns it
Day 12	LinkedIn	Carousel or image post of stills with a quote from the film.	Marketing
Day 14	Sales	Check in with the sales team. Who's sent it? What did people say? Add the film to proposal templates and email signatures.	Sales lead
Day 15	Social	Third vertical cut.	Marketing
Day 17	Press / sector	Send the film and write-up to a trade publication, local press or sector newsletter where it's genuinely relevant.	Marketing / PR
Day 19	Email	A follow-up email to the list focused on one person from the film.	Marketing
Day 21	Recruitment	Add the film to job adverts, the careers page and LinkedIn job posts.	HR / hiring manager
Day 22	Social	Fourth vertical cut.	Marketing
Day 24	Events	Add the film to your event kit: stand screens (muted, with captions), talks, AGMs, open days.	Events
Day 26	LinkedIn	Founder post about what's happened since the film went out. Responses, conversations, what you learned making it.	Founder
Day 28	Paid (optional)	If you're running ads, test the short cut and the best-performing vertical cut against your current ads. Check the music licence covers paid use first.	Marketing
Day 30	Review	Look at the numbers in section 12. Decide which cuts to keep using and which to retire.	Marketing lead

Reusing it for a year

A good brand film doesn't go stale in a month. Plan for it to work for at least a year.

Month	Idea
2	Release remaining vertical cuts, one a week
3	Pull a new short cut for a specific audience (recruitment, a particular service, a funder)
4	Use stills across the website, brochures and pitch decks
5	Repost the best-performing cut with a new caption
6	Show it at events, open days, trade shows, conferences
7	Quote lines from it in a sales email sequence
8	Add to your onboarding for new staff, so they understand why the organisation exists
9	A "where are they now" post on one of the contributors
10	Use clips in a funding bid, tender or award entry
11	Repost on the anniversary of the shoot or the founding
12	Review: is it still true? Does anything need updating? Is it time for the next one?

The people who get the most out of a film hand it to whoever's having the important conversations: sales, hiring, fundraising, the board.



Measuring it

What to track, and what worked actually looks like.

You can't judge a film by views alone. A film watched to the end by forty of the right people can do more than one seen for three seconds by forty thousand. So decide what it's for first (that's section 3 of your brief), then track the things that tell you whether it's doing that job.

What to track

On the film itself

- Plays and unique viewers, per platform
- Average percentage watched, or average view duration. This is the one I'd look at first. It tells you whether people actually stayed.
- Where people drop off. A big drop at the same moment usually points at a slow section or a weak opening.
- Shares, saves and comments, particularly comments from people you'd want to reach
- For the short cut on the website: how many people click through to the full film

On the website

- Time on the page where the film lives, compared to before
- Conversion rate on that page (enquiries, sign-ups, donations, applications) compared to the same page before the film
- Visits to the contact page from the film page

In the business

- How often the sales team actually sends it
- Replies to sales emails that include the film compared to ones that don't
- Prospects mentioning the film on calls
- Job applicants mentioning the film, and the quality of applicants
- Enquiries where the person says "I saw your film"
- Funders, partners or press responding to it

Add a "How did you hear about us?" question to your contact form if you don't have one, and include the film as an option.

What "worked" looks like

It depends entirely on the job you gave it. Set the measure before release, not after.

If the film was for...	It's working if...
Building trust before purchase	Prospects mention it, sales cycles feel shorter, the people who enquire already understand what you do
Supporting sales	The team actually uses it, and replies or meetings from emails with the film are better than those without
Recruitment	Better-fitting applicants, more of them mention it, fewer people drop out after the first interview
Fundraising or funding bids	Funders reference it, it gets shown at board or panel level, donations from people who've watched it
Heritage or community	It's shown, shared and talked about by the community it's about. Local press or partner organisations pick it up
Launch or campaign	It's the centre of the campaign and the most-watched or most-shared piece in it

A simple tracker					
Metric	Before film (baseline)	Day 30	Day 90	Month 12	Notes
Average % watched (main film)	n/a				
Average % watched (short cut)	n/a				
Plays across all platforms	n/a				
Enquiries per month					
Conversion rate on film page					
Times sent by sales team	n/a				
Prospects mentioning the film	n/a				
Applicants mentioning the film	n/a				
Other (your goal)					
Write down your baseline numbers before the film goes out. Without them you'll never really know what changed, and you'll be guessing when someone asks if it was worth it.					



If you can't afford a film yet: the phone-filming guide

How to make something good on the phone in your pocket.

If you've read this far and the honest answer is "not this year", that's completely fine. You can make something good on the phone in your pocket. It won't look like a cinema-camera documentary, and it doesn't need to. A real person telling a real story with clear sound will beat a polished advert that says nothing.

Here's how to do it properly.

The kit (most of which you already have)

Item	Why	Rough cost
Your phone (anything from the last few years)	Camera	Already got it
A tripod with a phone clamp	Steady shots, and you can step away	£15 to £40
A clip-on lav microphone (wired, or a small wireless kit)	Sound is the biggest difference between amateur and decent	£20 to £150
A cheap LED light (optional)	Fills in shadows on a grey day	£20 to £60
Spare storage and a charger	4K eats space and battery	You'll find one

If you only buy one thing, buy the microphone. People will forgive average pictures. They switch off at bad sound within seconds.

Phone settings

- **Clean the lens.** It's been in your pocket. Wipe it with a soft cloth every time. This genuinely fixes a lot of "my phone video looks hazy".
- **Use the main (1x) lens** for interviews. The ultra-wide distorts faces.
- **Resolution: 4K if you've got the storage, otherwise 1080p.** Both are fine.
- **Frame rate: 25fps in the UK.** Lighting here runs on a 50Hz supply, and filming at 25fps (or 50fps) avoids the flicker you can get under indoor lights at other frame rates. Use 50fps only if you want slow-motion B-roll.
- **Lock exposure and focus.** On most phones you tap and hold on the subject's face until a lock icon appears. This stops the picture pulsing brighter and darker as people move.
- **Turn on the grid** in camera settings. It helps with framing.
- **Turn off HDR video if your editing app struggles with it**, or if colours look strange when you share the files. Plenty of people leave it on with no problems, so test it once.

- **Airplane mode and Do Not Disturb.** A call mid-interview ruins the take.
- **Want more control?** Blackmagic's free Camera app (iPhone and Android) gives you manual frame rate, shutter, white balance and audio levels. If you use it, set your shutter to 1/50 for 25fps, which keeps motion looking natural.

Light

- **Use a window.** Put the person side-on to a large window, at about 45 degrees, so the light falls across their face. It's the best free light you'll find.
- **Never put the window behind them.** They'll turn into a silhouette.
- **Turn off overhead lights** if they're making harsh shadows under the eyes, or if they're a different colour to the daylight. Mixed light looks muddy.
- **Avoid direct sunlight on faces.** Too harsh. Overcast days are your friend.
- **Use the cheap LED** on the side away from the window to soften the shadows, not to flood the face.
- **Check the background.** A little depth behind them (a room, a workshop) looks better than a flat wall right behind their head. Move them a couple of metres forward.

Sound

- **Clip the mic about a hand's width below the chin**, in the middle of the chest, on a top or a button placket. Keep it away from necklaces, lanyards and hair.
- **Hide the wire under the top** and tape it if it rubs.
- **Pick a quiet room.** Soft furnishings help: curtains, sofas, carpet, bookshelves. Empty rooms with hard walls echo.
- **Turn things off.** Fridges, fans, air con, music, coffee machines. Put a note on the door.
- **Record a ten-second test and listen back with headphones.** Every single time. Rustling, buzzing and wind are much easier to fix before you start.
- **Record thirty seconds of silence in each room** before you finish. Your editing app can use it to cover gaps.
- **Outdoors, use the fluffy windshield** that came with the mic. Wind noise can't be fixed afterwards.

Framing an interview

- **Phone at the person's eye height.** Never looking up their nose or down on their head.
- **Shoot horizontal for YouTube and your website; vertical for Reels, TikTok and Shorts.** If you need both, shoot horizontal 4K with plenty of space around the person

and crop later, or film it twice.

- **Medium close-up:** from the middle of the chest to just above the head, eyes roughly a third of the way down the frame.
- **Put them slightly to one side** of the frame (on the grid lines), with more space in the direction they're looking.
- **The interviewer sits just beside the phone**, so the person looks slightly off-camera at them. That's the documentary look. If you want them talking straight to the viewer, have them look at the lens, but most people find that harder.
- **Keep the background tidy** without making it look staged.

Interviewing someone (including yourself)

- Use the questions in section 4.
- Have a conversation. Look at them, react, let them talk.
- Remind them to include the question in the answer.
- Stay quiet while they speak. Nod, don't "mm-hm".
- Let it run long. Twenty to forty minutes of conversation can make a three minute film.
- If you're filming yourself, put a friend behind the camera to ask the questions. Talking to a person is far easier than talking to a lens.

Getting B-roll on a phone

- Use section 9. Wide, mid, close for every action.
- Hold each shot for ten seconds without moving.
- If you do move, move slowly and smoothly. Walk heel to toe, hold the phone with two hands and keep your elbows tucked in.
- Get in close. The phone's best shots are details: hands, tools, textures.
- Don't zoom digitally. Walk closer instead.

Editing apps

App	Platform	Cost	Good for
iMovie	iPhone, iPad, Mac	Free	Simple, clean edits if you're on Apple
DaVinci Resolve	Windows, Mac, Linux, iPad	Free version available	Proper editing, colour and sound tools. Steeper learning curve, but worth it
CapCut	Phone, desktop, web	Free with paid extras	Quick vertical edits and auto captions
LumaFusion	iPhone, iPad, Android	One-off paid	A full editor on a phone or tablet

Whichever you use, check its current terms before you upload client or staff footage, and check that any built-in music or effects are cleared for commercial use. Free in-app music often isn't licensed for business use.

A simple editing order

1. Watch everything back and mark the best moments (a few words in a note with the timecode is enough).
2. Build the story from the interview only. Ignore pictures. Does it make sense with your eyes shut?
3. Cut it shorter. Then shorter again. For a first film, two to three minutes is plenty.
4. Lay B-roll over the interview where it helps the viewer see what's being talked about.
5. Add music quietly under it, only if it helps. Leave it out if it fights the voice.
6. Add captions and proofread every word.
7. Watch it on your phone, with and without sound, before you post it.

Doing it yourself first isn't a waste of time, even if you hire someone later. You'll know what goes into it, you'll write a better brief, and you'll know exactly which bits you want someone else to take off your hands.

Got a story worth filming?

Tell me about the business: who's in it, what they do, and why you think there's a story there. We come back within one working day, and if we don't think there's a film in it, we'll say so.

s4digi.com/contact

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